

Woodlands



THE BROADLEAVED WOODLANDS of Europe provide food and shelter for a rich variety of animals. Insects feed on the leaves, birds and mammals nest in the trunks and branches, and creatures such as woodlice and beetles live in the leaf litter on the woodland floor.

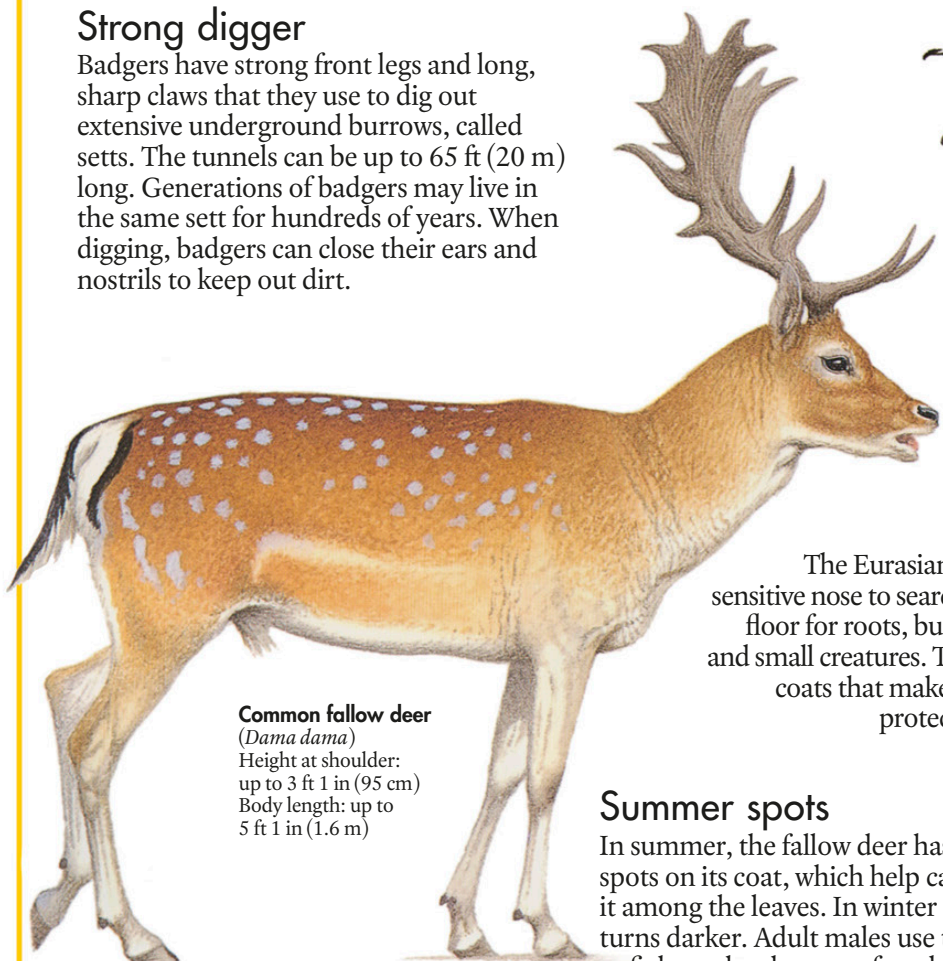
The weather changes with the seasons, and this affects animal behavior. In the warm spring days, insects emerge, birds begin to nest, and young mammals are born. In the hot summer months, there is plenty of food and young animals grow quickly. In the fall, most of the trees lose their leaves, and the animals feast on fruits and berries or store food for the winter. The long, cold nights and short days make winter difficult for animals. Many grow thick coats and spend more time in their homes. Some birds fly away to spend the winter in warmer climates.



European badger (*Meles meles*)
Body length: up to 3 ft (90 cm)
Tail: up to 8 in (20 cm)

Strong digger

Badgers have strong front legs and long, sharp claws that they use to dig out extensive underground burrows, called setts. The tunnels can be up to 65 ft (20 m) long. Generations of badgers may live in the same sett for hundreds of years. When digging, badgers can close their ears and nostrils to keep out dirt.



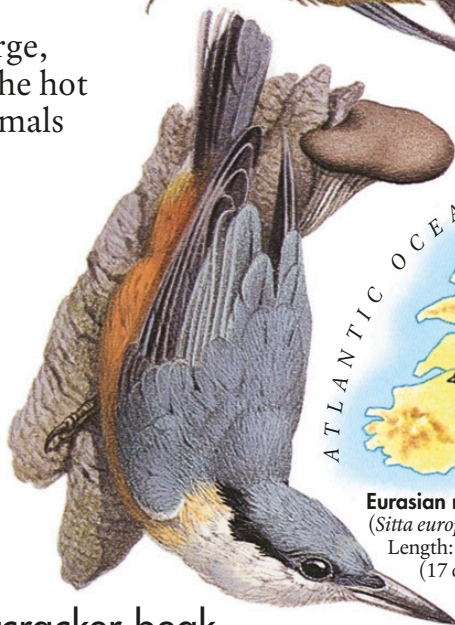
Common fallow deer (*Dama dama*)
Height at shoulder: up to 3 ft 1 in (95 cm)
Body length: up to 5 ft 1 in (1.6 m)

Summer spots

In summer, the fallow deer has white spots on its coat, which help camouflage it among the leaves. In winter its coat turns darker. Adult males use their antlers to fight each other over females.



Eurasian blue tit (*Cyanistes caeruleus*)
Length: up to 4.7 in (12 cm)

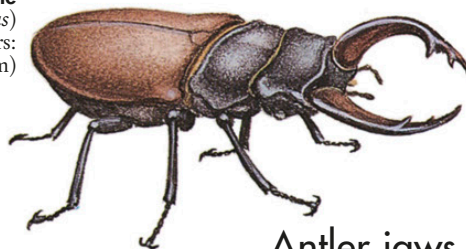


Eurasian nuthatch (*Sitta europaea*)
Length: up to 6.7 in (17 cm)

Nutcracker beak

The nuthatch often wedges a nut in the bark of a tree and hammers it open with its beak. It is the only bird that can climb headfirst down trees, searching for insects under the bark as it moves.

European stag beetle (*Lucanus cervus*)
Length including antlers: up to 3 in (7.5 cm)

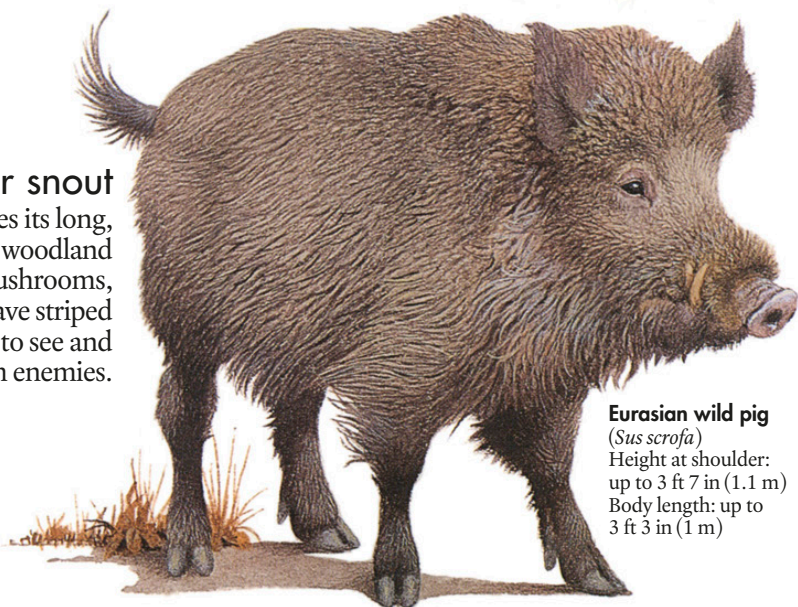


Antler jaws

The male European stag beetle has huge jaws that look like stags' antlers. He uses them to fight rivals. Females lay eggs in rotting wood, which the larvae feed on until adulthood.

Super snout

The Eurasian wild pig uses its long, sensitive nose to search along the woodland floor for roots, bulbs, nuts, mushrooms, and small creatures. The young have striped coats that make them hard to see and protect them from enemies.



Eurasian wild pig (*Sus scrofa*)
Height at shoulder: up to 3 ft 7 in (1.1 m)
Body length: up to 3 ft 3 in (1 m)

Caterpillar diet
In spring and summer, blue tits feed their young mainly on caterpillars. While the young are in the nest, their parents may bring them more than 10,000 items of food. In winter, blue tits feed in mixed flocks with other small birds.



Northern Europe has a warm, wet climate; many rivers flow through the woodlands.